

Paragraph / section function - Study Guide

Explain the job a sentence, paragraph, or section performs in the larger text.

Learning goal

Identify how a specific part of a text contributes to the writer's overall meaning, structure, explanation, or argument.

What this skill really means

Function questions are not asking only what a paragraph says. They ask why that paragraph is there and what job it performs in relation to the rest of the text.

The same information can perform different jobs: introduce a problem, give an example, define a term, provide evidence, acknowledge a limitation, show a result, or shift the discussion.

A strong answer links the local content to the larger purpose of the passage. Summarizing the paragraph is often not enough.

If the paragraph...	Its likely function	Evidence to notice
describes a difficulty before a proposed change	sets up a problem	problem details followed by a response or solution
gives one concrete case after a general claim	provides an example	general statement followed by a specific instance
reports numbers, observations, or findings	provides evidence	data or facts connected to a claim

If the paragraph...	Its likely function	Evidence to notice
mentions a drawback after describing benefits	qualifies or limits a claim	however, although, still, limitation language
explains what happened after an action	shows a result or consequence	outcomes, changes, effects
introduces a new idea that the rest develops	shifts or advances the discussion	transition plus a new focus

How exam-style questions ask it

- What is the main function of paragraph 4?
- How does the final paragraph contribute to the passage?
- Why does the author include the example in paragraph 2?
- What role does this sentence play in the author's explanation?

A reliable method

1. Read the target paragraph and summarize it in a few words.
2. Read the paragraph immediately before and after it.
3. Ask what changed: Did the writer move from problem to solution, claim to evidence, general idea to example, or benefit to limitation?
4. State the job with a verb: introduces, illustrates, supports, contrasts, qualifies, explains, concludes.
5. Choose the option that explains both what the paragraph contains and how it serves the larger text.

Tips and shortcuts

- Use a function verb. "It talks about costs" is content; "it acknowledges a cost that limits the proposal" is function.
- Check neighboring paragraphs. Function is relational, so the answer often depends on what comes before or after.

- A paragraph can do more than one small thing, but exam questions usually ask for its primary contribution.

Worked examples

Example 1

A town report first explains that summer bus stops can become dangerously hot. The next paragraph describes a pilot program that installed shade canopies at twelve stops and measured surface temperatures before and after installation.

1. What is the main function of the second paragraph?

- A. It introduces the problem of hot bus stops.
- B. It describes a response used to address the problem.
- C. It argues that buses should run less often.
- D. It defines the term surface temperature.

Answer: B

The first paragraph establishes the problem. The second moves to the action taken in response, so its primary function is to describe the response.

Example 2

A workplace memo lists three benefits of a new scheduling system. The final paragraph notes that employees without reliable internet may need an alternative way to request changes.

2. How does the final paragraph contribute to the memo?

- A. It repeats the benefits in different words.
- B. It gives the history of the company.
- C. It acknowledges a limitation that must be addressed.
- D. It proves the system has already failed.

Answer: C

The final paragraph introduces a practical limitation after the benefits, qualifying the earlier positive description.

Common traps

- A correct summary of the paragraph that never explains its job.
- A function that belongs to another paragraph.
- An answer that describes the topic of the whole passage rather than the target section.
- A vague answer such as "adds more information" when a more precise relationship is available.

Self-check rule

Before accepting an answer, name the exact relationship between the target wording and the larger text. Point to evidence for that relationship, not just a familiar label.

Quick check

1. A paragraph gives a specific story immediately after a general claim. What function is most likely?
2. How is "describes the cost" different from "qualifies the proposal by describing a cost"?
3. Why should you read the paragraphs around the target paragraph?

Quick check guidance

Explain the relationship in plain language before using a technical label. If your explanation works only as a summary, ask what job, purpose, perspective, or effect is still missing.

Diagnostic help

Use the mistake pattern to decide what to change on your next question.

1

If: You summarize what the paragraph says instead of explaining its job.

Try: Use a function verb: introduces, provides evidence, gives an example, contrasts, qualifies, explains, or concludes.

2

If: Your function could describe almost any paragraph in the passage.

Try: Connect the paragraph to what comes before and after. Its job is relational, not isolated.

3

If: You confuse the purpose of one detail with the purpose of the whole paragraph.

Try: Zoom out one level and ask what the paragraph accomplishes as a unit.

30-second reset

Before the next paragraph / section function question: restate the target, point to the evidence, and reject any choice that needs an extra assumption.